

PEARS *Pyrus communis*

When harvested at their sweet and juicy best, pears are simply unbeatable. They are delicious eaten fresh, used in cooking, or bottled in alcohol and stored for later use. Although less widely grown than apples, they can be just as easy, are vulnerable to fewer pests and diseases, and are arguably much tastier—just give them a sheltered site and provide them with some frost protection in winter.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Choose your trees carefully: if you have only a small space, pears can be grown on a semi-dwarfing rootstock. These types will need around 10 ft (3 m) of space between trees, whereas more vigorous types need about 15 ft (5 m). They can be grown as free-standing trees or trained; fans, cordons, or espaliers are ideal for a south-facing wall, since pears require more heat and sunshine than apples.

Although some pear cultivars are classified as partially self-fertile, all will benefit from pollination from another tree, so choose carefully, selecting trees that will flower within the same period. Bear in mind that pear pollination can be complicated:



Allow trees plenty of space to develop.

there are some trees that produce very poor pollen and make unsatisfactory pollenizers (although they are not suggested in the pear catalog of this book). Some combinations of trees will simply not pollinate each other, such as 'Doyenné du Comice' and 'Onward', while others are triploid—meaning that they need at least two other pollenizers to produce fruit.